

An Endless Fascination with Golf

“Golf is the closest game to the game we call life. You get bad breaks from good shots; you get good breaks from bad shots – but you have to play the ball where it lies”

- Bobby Jones

There are layers upon layers to the game of golf that pave the way for a lifelong pursuit of endless fascination. The ageless dimension provides a platform for lifetime relationships and an invaluable meeting place of the generations. Packed full of randomness, the game is a metaphor for life, one where the challenge is as much philosophical as it is sporting. It is a crucible for the recurring trials of patience, resilience and emotional regulation.

Fascinatingly, the game’s difficulty setting can vary from a joyful recreational pursuit to Sisyphean torture. A powerful life coach or Groundhog Day for the demented. Choose that difficulty setting wisely.

Let’s start with golf’s elemental attraction, the intrinsic exhilaration at the heart of the game. In everyday lives full of constraints and responsibilities, golf provides embodied moments of freedom, abandon and joy. It is an undeniably hard game, as any beginner will testify, but the experience of a perfectly struck shot is a recurring dopamine hit. Looking up from whatever move you make at the ball and seeing it fly straight and true never gets old. No recreational activity lasts for centuries without fundamental truth at the heart of the process.

A palpable sense of freedom has been at the core of Rory’s extraordinary level of fan connection. He is the hometown boy wherever he competes, from Melbourne to The Masters and everywhere in between. The pied piper of any given week. He plays the game free of inhibition and therein lies his universal resonance. When connection crosses all manner of age and national boundaries, as it does with Rory, you know there’s something deeper at play. It’s a quest for freedom that few of us ever attain.

Surprisingly, this perspective originated in a business case I covered in INSEAD, many years before I was aware of Rory or ever likely to work within the game. It was based on Callaway Golf and its founder Ely Callaway. When they launched their Big Bertha driver in 1991, it was a radical departure from the contemporary drivers of the time. Ely’s primary insight centred on human nature, rather than physics or aerodynamics. Understanding the subliminal magic of longer, straighter drives for the average golfer, he priced the Big Bertha at a significant premium to its competitors. Ely was on the money. When that sense of freedom and exhilaration was on the menu, club golfers became remarkably price-insensitive. Callaway couldn’t manufacture the Big Berthas fast enough, despite the super-premium pricing.

Time spent outdoors enveloped in nature is a compelling part of the golf experience, especially for urbanites. Few other leisure pursuits provide such extended time in places of natural beauty. This was crystallised for a generation of new golfers during the COVID pandemic, the unexpected catalyst for a sustained global surge in golf participation. This new cohort of younger golfers have stayed with the game, further testament to its enduring appeal.

Passing the golf torch from parent to child is one of the game's purest attributes. My earliest memories of the game are with my mother, generally early mornings in Athy Golf Club. The game provides parents with the increasingly valuable opportunity to spend extended time with their children. Proper quality time away from phones and screens. This is a lifelong window that extends to grandchildren. Few pursuits can provide this dynamic platform for connection across the generations. Mom never had more than a handful of pars in her twenty odd years playing the game but she treasured those Summer mornings beyond any scoring outcome. Mornings that always concluded with ice cream on the way home.

My equivalent journey with Ciara and Sean has been the highlight of my lifelong love affair with the game. In Hermitage, it was more evenings than mornings for our golf windows but the connection was the same. As were the ceremonial treats to mark each outing. Our family golf journey turned into quite the odyssey as they both quickly became proficient at the game. Despite playing more camogie than golf at the time, Ciara went from novice to playing for Ireland in just two years. Sean was juggling more sports but he still got close to scratch and played in many national Boys' championships. Watching them take to the game was a wonderful experience, creating bonds and memories that have only deepened over time.

Already covered in the Self-Confidence chapter, a feature of younger golf journeys is the early and increasing exposure they have to adults. When advocating for the game with parents, this informal tuition in adult interaction always ranks high in my selling points. Children can gain so much social confidence within the Golf Club environment. It undoubtedly gives them a head start in future workplaces. The right culture is critical but the great majority of club members are proud and delighted to see younger people blossoming at the game.

Although traditionally viewed as an elitist domain, there is an egalitarian core to the game which might be its secret sauce. A great leveller, the handicap system is a significant part of the glue that binds players together. It levels the playing field for everyone, enabling competition across widely divergent skill levels. Likewise the different tee markers are tailored to a broad range of capabilities, all still playing the same golf course. What an amazing feature for any pursuit? Imagine the implausibility of Roger Federer playing with the 20 handicap equivalent in tennis? Or the futility of a chess grandmaster being paired with a novice. We are all created equally in the eyes of the World Handicap System (WHS).

The WHS also opens up another fundamental truth about the game - the ultimate competition is the one with ourselves. How much better would life be if we were all competing against ourselves from yesterday, rather than half the world on Instagram? Golf is such a journey, one that never ends, celebrating the experience over any sense of a final destination. I have seen 80 year olds remain as consumed by the search for improvement as 20 year olds. Their handicap provides direct and dynamic feedback for this lifelong process.

In these increasingly ill-mannered times, golf carries a flickering candle for civility via the code of etiquette that is woven into the game. Total strangers can spend four hours together in an atmosphere of mutual respect and politeness. An invisible dance unfolds over the round that looks seamless from the outside. Players know when to play, when to be still and where to stand. Embedded in the process is a pervasive sense of respect and self-regulation.

Against these norms, the 2025 Ryder Cup was quite the show. A century old rivalry, normally a safe haven of good manners and courtesy, descended into an ugly spectacle of nativist and personalised abuse. When the official first tee announcer is leading the gallery in chants of “F*** you, Rory”, you know for sure that civility norms are in flux. At least, we can safely speculate that the Irish galleries in 2027 will look positively angelic in comparison.

I have always been a keen observer of new playing partners. Spending four hours with total strangers is another fascinating feature of golf. You will likely know more about a person after just 18 holes of golf than after any number of structured interviews. Something about the game reveals our true nature, notably in the realm of emotional regulation. Einstein’s definition of madness is regularly on show as so many players repeat the same emotional responses whilst expecting different results. Even the most accomplished players struggle to break free of unhelpful patterns. I’m surprised more companies don’t use the game in their talent recruitment process. It is a high quality lie detector test.

Another wonderful dimension to the game is the rich seam of honour that runs through it. There are myriad ways to cheat at golf from nudging your ball into a better lie to falsifying your score or fudging your handicap. Only a tiny fraction of players ever avail of them. Integrity is what we do when no-one is watching. Golf doesn’t just reveal character, it helps to build it also.

The recreational game comes packed with an extraordinary array of benefits, encompassing its physical, mental and social attributes. The icing on the cake is the broader health realm. This apparently crazy pursuit ticks a host of healthy ageing boxes. Repeated studies have shown that golf participation leads to consistently better health outcomes and multiple added years of lifespan. A good walk spoiled, I think not.

Let’s conclude this bottom-up celebration of the game with a shout-out for Ireland. Over the past 20 years, we have accounted for a staggering 11 major championships, comfortably the highest per capita in the world. The country stands as a counter point to the perceived (and actual) privilege within the game. At the heart of this national success is accessibility. With over 400 golf courses dotted around a small island, the game is played in every community, right across the socio-economic spectrum. The likelihood of natural talent being identified and nurtured is high. Much higher than in other countries. Our individual major winners all come from humble backgrounds. Golf in Ireland is a representation of the best the game has to offer, something which over 200,000 ardent visitors testify to each year.

Stepping back for a broader perspective, these are compelling times for the game's ecosystem. Perceptions of a staid and stuffy pastime are firmly out of date. Golf is now a changing world in microcosm. The COVID-driven explosion of interest in golf amongst Gen Z is one such dimension. A fascinating clash of generational perspectives has ensued as new meets old in a game that elevates tradition and heritage above all else. An active interface between the Boomers and Gen Z was always going to be intriguing. Surprisingly, it is Gen Z setting the agenda. The participation surge is being fuelled by novel forms of the game, notably TopGolf, driving ranges and simulators. YouTube, the world's most used streaming service, has usurped the traditional media outlets as the game's primary communication platform. A game that appeared to be in slow but inexorable decline has been re-invigorated by a COVID stimulus and new technology.

LIV Golf has placed the sport at the centre of the global wave of sports washing. As covered in "The Priceless Value of Sport", countries are looking to sport to help diversify their economies (mostly away from oil and gas) and rebrand their national reputations. Sports washing is an emotional subject given the enduring and inter-generational nature of our sporting passions. Within golf, two apparently opposing ideas can be true at the same time. Firstly, selling sporting affinities and traditions to the highest bidder is unsettling, socially and culturally. Secondly, Saudi Arabia is 100% right to identify professional golf as an immensely valuable soft power platform for its long-term national objectives. Their willingness to invest billions of dollars in golf is a stunning vote of confidence in this apparently boring game.

Interestingly, the disruptor that is LIV Golf has infused its approach with some of the Gen Z influences highlighted above. Shotgun starts for a tighter TV window, wider on-site entertainment for the more casual fan and 54 hole tournaments are all ideas that may eventually find their way into the mainstream tours. Apparently driven by the quest for world ranking points, LIV Golf's recent decision to revert to 72 hole tournaments surprised me. Declining attention spans are a global reality way above golf's pay grade.

Another dynamic clearly visible within the golf ecosystem is ever-widening wealth inequality. As rich as the top players might be, their wealth pales in comparison with the game's adjacent wealth, just outside the ropes. Extreme wealth is drawn to the game like moths to a flame. The rich and famous can actually play with the stars and build relationships with them. It is a remarkable concept, unmatched in any other sport. Imagine the music equivalent of jamming with Coldplay or Oasis in a packed arena. Pro-Am days have been a feature of the professional game for decades, enabling the seamless mixing of golf, business and wider celebrity on a weekly basis.

This adjacent wealth has rendered professional golf far richer than its viewership base. This same audience populates a raft of tight networks within elite golf clubs, preserving and deepening privilege. It is these networks of power and influence that makes golf such an attractive proposition for the Public Investment Fund of Saudi Arabia, the world's largest sovereign wealth fund.

Professional golf illuminates the nature of rewards in globalised markets. Global talent pyramids are harsh and unforgiving. The winners, measured in units of ten, are vastly outnumbered by the struggling aspirants, measured in units of a thousand. The PGA Tour is the premier global platform for men's professional golf, showcasing the world's best players on a weekly basis. The financial rewards are life-changing. Beyond the bright lights and the curated narratives on our screens, it is a brutally competitive environment. There are thousands of young and not so young professionals striving to reach the mountain top. Living the dream for them involves a life of ceaseless toil, struggle and sacrifice. There are irreversible opportunity costs in devoting those vital career formation years to a mission with such a low probability of success. It's the hope that kills you.

From the parallel context of professional tennis, you will not find a better account of the life of the average professional athlete than Conor Niland's recent memoir, "The Racket". Absent of self-pity, he zoned in on the relentless grind and economic fragility of the aspiring sportsperson.

The professional games of tennis and golf provide observable examples of globalised markets. Figuratively, I refer to them as a 1/99 structures, where the 1% of winners are framed by the 99% of aspirants. Such imbalances have always been present in professional sport but global pyramids are nascent in so many other fields of human endeavour. Steadily expanding the frontiers of inequality. The profile of Spotify's royalties is a case in point. A tiny fraction of the creators on the platform generate huge royalties each year but there are millions of smaller payments stretching from €10,000 side hustles into artistic penury. Dreams don't come cheap.

Ciara's golf journey offered some fleeting insight to this dynamic. She reached the 500's in the World Amateur Golf Rankings, no mean feat, but still a virtual universe away from the professional game. In 2018, she played in the regional qualifying for the Women's British Open. Although, it was real life for most of the participants, we were tourists in the bottom tier of a global professional sport. Held just outside London, a decent number of the competitors were sleeping in their cars or makeshift camper vans. Economic scarcity and precariousness was visible everywhere. After the practice round, we went back to our hotel and watched Roger Federer and Novak Djokovic duel it out in the Wimbledon final. A day that spanned the full spectrum of professional sport.

Within professional golf's reward structures, the gender pay gap remains stubbornly high. As a broad number, women play the sport for 85% less than men. Leaving the Rory world has enabled me to spend some time around the women's professional game. For the past two years, I have played with Sara Byrne in the amateur component of the Lacoste Women's French Open. It has been a fascinating inside-the-ropes experience. The talent levels are phenomenal. The players have all emerged from the same unforgiving filters of elite international amateur and US collegiate golf. The actual golf is much more relatable than the rockets being launched in the men's game. Human stories are everywhere you look. Girls in sport have generally had to swim against the tide during their teenage years. There must be potential to reduce this yawning pay gap.

Progress is slowly emerging but I sense a cultural deficit within the women's game when it comes to tapping into that adjacent wealth. As a counter point, Rory was always exceptional with his Pro-Am partners. It's also hard to escape the reality that women business executives and golf fans could be doing more to support their own icons. Those two ideas are part of a self-reinforcing dynamic.

I opened the chapter with reference to golf's unlimited potential for pain and pleasure. For a supposedly recreational pursuit, it can drive some players demented. Especially those who are accustomed to achievement, control and power elsewhere in their lives. Money can buy lots of things but it can't buy golf without its incorrigible dispersion. I sometimes refer to golf as "God's punishment for rich people" - only partially in jest.

A mercurial and fickle game, it is virtually designed to unearth and exploit frailties in the human temperament. Randomness is everywhere; the uneven terrain, the ever-changing weather, trees that are definitely not 90% air and the ubiquitous rub of the green. Even the ball is an imperfect sphere with its hundreds of dimples. Expectations, set by our best moments, are often the enemy. They become an instrument of self-flagellation with frustration baked-in to the experience. Even for the greatest players, it supplies an ongoing stream of disappointments, framed against occasional victories.

The capacity to accept the game's inherent variability is the primary tenet of modern golf psychology. As Bobby Jones advised, playing the ball where it lies, no matter how it got there, is the essence of the game. Acceptance is universally held out as the optimal mindset. One psychological step beyond acceptance is the rarefied space of actually embracing the capricious nature of the game. That is golfing nirvana.

The game's timeless trap is that some version of perfection exists to deliver us from its vagaries. It takes us back to the talent chapter and the control paradigm that runs so pervasively through society. We remain permanently suspended between this search for control and just playing with what we have. Determined as we might be to avoid this trap, those whispering voices promising redemption are ever-present. On the practice ground, on YouTube, on social media and in the winning narratives that unfold each week. This prospect of salvation is an illusion, a mirage shimmering in the middle distance. We never get there.

Nick Faldo has a lot to answer for. He famously broke down a winning golf swing and reconstructed it under the guidance of David Leadbetter. He proceeded to win six majors in eight years. As with the Tiger Woods reference in the opening chapter, his story is one of statistical anomaly rather than any form of blueprint. 99.9% of golfers who embark on the reconstruction path never make it through the valley. It makes sense. Experienced golfers are a least a million shots into their golfing journey. The neural pathways around their signature movements are wired into their brains. Conceptually, remodelling them is so unlikely to work. Even Rory, the most naturally gifted player of his generation, failed with a swing change process with Pete Cowen in 2021. Figuratively and actually, the mission ended in tears at that year's Ryder Cup. Michael Bannon, his childhood coach, oversaw his subsequent renaissance that culminated in the career grand slam.

Padraig Harrington is a legend of the game and, in my opinion, the poster child for embracing the elemental essence of golf. He never cared for the aesthetics, he just found a way to shoot 71 when his game was not quite firing. That laid the foundations for 65's when his biorhythms were in sequence. For sure, he had worked tirelessly with Bob Torrance, but Padraig's mind was his most potent weapon. During those magical years of 2007 and 2008, he was inarguably the strongest mind in golf. After that golden window of three majors, even he fell prey to the searching, proving that no-one is immune from the whispering. Padraig will always be celebrated as the man who started the cascade of Irish major winners. It had nothing to do with perfection.

Another pattern I discerned from being around the top players in the game was a reality distortion process. One where the bad shots faded rapidly from the memory, whilst retaining vivid images of the good ones. Rory was exceptional in this regard, as was his Dad, Gerry. Irrespective of the circumstances, theirs was always a distinctly positive framing of the situation. A 90/10 principle seemed to apply whereby 90% of the attention got directed at the positives, leaving only 10% for rumination on the bad stuff. It is unusual because our evolutionary wiring operates firmly in the opposite direction. Negative experiences and danger signals naturally get amplified in our minds. The parallels between golf and life are multiple and many. This elusive blend of positivity and resilience would be a blessing for any life journey.

The estimated number of active golfers in the world varies depending on the source and definition of "active" used. A mid-range estimate of 70 million means that less than 1% of the world's population play golf. This brings us back to gratitude. If you are lucky enough to have the time and resources, firstly to learn the game, and then to play it regularly, you are assuredly in a privileged subset of humanity. I live on the fringes of our capital city but I get to play golf in the beautiful sylvan environment that is Hermitage. It has the River Liffey, 12,000 trees, natural rolling topography and the surprising sound of silence. Any day spent there is a lucky day.

So many of the themes running through this book manifest in golf. An understanding and embrace of randomness, the voluntary pathway to excellence, an egalitarian philosophy and a mindset of gratitude to name just a few. I'm not sure if I found these ideas in golf or if the game discovered them in me. That first visit to Athy Golf Club has cast a long and golden shadow over my life. Happily, albeit slowly and falteringly, I have journeyed to a place where the pleasure I derive from the game is mostly separated from the scoring outcome. All things are truly possible.

In a crowded contest, my favourite characteristic of golf is that it is a pursuit where we can all be winners. That rich, layered and embodied experience is available to the many rather than the few. Other activities, where the real competition is with ourselves, such as marathon running, exhibit the same pattern. The world needs more of these. The winner-takes-all model, inherent in global talent pyramids, is a terrible and expanding template for humanity.